NATIONAL POWER

What makes the United States of America the most powerful state in the world? Should India follow a favourable policy towards USA? What should be the equation between USA and Russia in their relationships? How does USA figure in the Indo-Pak relations? Thousands of such questions can be raised, but the answer is that the disposition of a particular state in the international arena is based on its national power.

Power is seen "as the ability to get another actor to do what it would not otherwise have done (or not to do what it would have done).[9] Power, therefore, is a relationship. If thought in terms of international relations, then the state's attempt to influence others, to a great extent, is determined by its own capabilities, goals, policies and actions which is similarly affected by the behaviour of those with which it interacts.

Power, in the context of world politics, can be seen as:

- A set of attributes or capabilities
- An influence process
- Ability to control resources, behaviour of other states, events, outcomes of interaction (cooperative or conflictual).

Couloumbis and Wolfe produced an umbrella concept of power that denotes anything that establishes and maintains control of one actor over the other. They conceive power as having three elements—force, influence and authority (see Figure 3.1). Force, can be defined as the explicit threat or the use of military, economic and other instruments of coercion by one actor against another in pursuit of its political objectives. Influence, is seen as the use of instruments of persuasion, short of force, in order to maintain or alter the behaviour of one actor in the way as preferred by the other actor. Authority, means the compliance by one actor to the directives issued by another actor nurtured by its own perception of respect, solidarity, affection, affinity, leadership, knowledge and expertise regarding that actor.[10]